



extending borders: The West Indies will host two-thirds of the matches in the 2024 tournament, with the US staging the rest. GETTY IMAGES

WHEN USA CRICKET'S APPLICATION TO JOIN THE ICC WAS APPROVED IN 2019, CRICKET ADMINISTRATION GOT BETTER STREAMLINED

undeniable. Tendulkar and Warne were suitably impressed, terming the series a success. If matches involving players well past their prime proved to be a hit, then the 2024 ICC Men's T20 World Cup is sure to be a home run.

The premier cricket tournament makes a historic first visit to the USA, with India's group stage matches set

to be held in New York and Lauderhill (Florida). There is interest expected from those with roots in Pakistan and Sri Lanka as well, but the ICC counts on the Indian fans to turn up in large numbers.

Rakesh Badlani was among the many who travelled to Los Angeles to cheer on Tendulkar and other stars. Badlani is an active tennis-ball cricketer in the Bay Area and cannot

wait for the World Cup to commence. "We used to travel to the West Indies and England to watch the Indian team play. Now that the World Cup is happening in the USA, we do not have to travel too far," Badlani said. Badlani had moved from Maharashtra to the USA in 2009 and joined the private tennis-ball leagues. Since the early days of playing matches on public grounds, the sport has now caught the attention of the local government. "Given the boom in tennis ball leagues, the city recognised the revenue potential in cricket. So now we have to get permits from the city to use the grounds. These grounds are in high demand; they must be reserved well in advance," Badlani said. The World Cup could pique the interest of local Americans. "Once in a while, a person born and raised in America will stop at our match and ask about cricket. They want to understand the sport, but this is rare," Badlani said.

Irfan Sait, Director and Chief Coach at Karnataka Institute of

Cricket (KIOC), realised the potential of taking his academy to the West. He started his coaching centre in San Francisco before moving to Atlanta. Many in the USA harbour big dreams—playing international cricket or even in the IPL. The key is to start young and learn the basics well. "Indians who have moved to the USA hold on to dreams and aspirations of playing professional cricket. This is passed on to their kids. Parents are willing to pay for good cricket infrastructure and facilities. The success of the IPL has got everyone's attention. They believe that their children can play